

LINCOLN PREPARATORY ACADEMY

Technology:

The Key to a Virtuous Life

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“I shall not seem to you to be too vain, if you will consider that, there being but one truth with respect to each thing, whoever finds this truth knows as much about a thing as can be known”

-Descartes, *Discourse on Method*

In the modern day, the fate of humanity hangs in the balance. The world is trapped in a cycle of never-ending destruction. People are trying to get ahead by any means possible.

Technology has evolved our society to an industrial age, and it is imperative that we as humans understand it before we are consumed. Technology can be a threat, but more importantly, it is the most effective way to seek truth. And without truth, humanity will be lost with or without the influence of technology. Truth is the fundamental concept that ties every object in the world together. Every entity has its own truth, and it is often reflected in the object's original purpose. The true purpose of technology is to better the human race. Humans need to embrace the truth and learn of their purpose, which will lead them to a more virtuous life. Likewise, all types of technology have this goal of improvement in mind. For example, everyday objects like lights, cars, phones, and much more all share this goal. They all have their own way of demonstrating technology's true purpose. The light allows for productivity, safety, and much more. The car allows for transportation, which leads to more exposure to the world and allows for more projects to occur. The phone, which is so often seen as a bad influence, gives one of humanity's greatest assets. Communication. With communication, the world becomes one connected human race rather than individual sections. It allows for trade and the exchange of goods. The ability to communicate strengthens relationships and allows for closer societies to form. With the formation of tight-knit societies, humans are able to work together for the better of everyone. Using technology's ability to reveal truth, these societies allow for humans to reach a greater, more virtuous life.

The use of the word technology in everyday life has created many misconceptions about what technology is. Technology includes more than most people realize. Technology is a development in the human world that advances humans as a race. It includes all kinds of developments, whether medical, educational, or militaristic. Through the use of these technological advancements, humans are able to discover the truth. The process technology uses to achieve truth is as such: it reveals the dangers to humanity, assists in solving these dangers, and finally protects humans from these dangers.

Dangers is defined as the threat to the existence of the human race. In Martin Heidegger's *On the Question Concerning Technology*, he highlights this danger that will ultimately destroy the human race. This danger is referred to as Enframing by Heidegger. Enframing is when an object or person loses its true purpose. Heidegger highlights this when he says, "It is precisely in Enframing, which threatens to sweep man away into ordering as the supposed single way of revealing, and so thrusts man into the danger of the surrender of his free essence" (Heidegger 32). Enframing is the danger where it takes over all other ways of expression and will ultimately lead to a loss of self. Heidegger attributes this loss of self to technology. He believes that the revealing technology it does is too forceful and causes a loss of purpose. He worries that if humans continue on this path of revelation through technology, they will cease to exist as humans. He proposes to use poetry as the true path to a virtuous life. However, this comes with many downsides that will be addressed later. Regardless, Heidegger emphasizes the increasing necessity to search for truth and discover purpose both in individuals and in societies.

Discovering truth is something humans have been chasing since the start of time. Truth creates the basis of all things in the world. It can come in many forms, ranging from words and actions to facts. Everything in our universe has a truth, and discovering this truth allows the

object to reach its full potential. With this ability, humans are able to arrive at a brighter future. Knowing the truth allows for problems and dangers to be revealed and subsequently dealt with. This weeding out of threats and preservation against these threats allows for humans to live a fuller life. A life where dangers to the existence of humanity are minimized allows for more time to be spent on reaching that virtuous life. People are able to focus their time and energy on bettering themselves rather than waste it on constantly only thinking about survival. Not only is the individual given a chance to better themselves, but the society itself will improve in the process.

The truth that technology allows is the purpose and identities of people and objects. Technology paves the way towards each and every unique purpose. Purpose is the true goal and intent of the object or person in question. While a person can have multiple hobbies and passions throughout their life, their true purpose never changes. A person's true purpose is intrinsic to them as people, and when working in conjunction with their passions, it defines them. Meanwhile, objects only have one true purpose, that which is from their origins. Now this leads to the big question: What is the purpose of technology? This question leads individuals to wonder and investigate the purpose of technology. Ultimately, they will discover that the purpose of technology is to free humans to pursue a virtuous life. Every action made with technology has this purpose in mind. This includes medicine, education, and even warfare.

The virtuous life is a lifestyle that is built around truth. This lifestyle is made up of two components, namely the individual and the societal. The individual component consists of one's own purpose and passion combined with human truth. Societal truth is found within the common good. This truth is focused on the benefits of the whole society, both efficiency-wise. A virtuous life needs both components, as a life is incomplete without the individual's intrinsic values and a moral code. This code is often referred to by philosophers as the natural law. The natural law is

the truth of humans as individuals, and it is a reference to how to act. The societal part is inherently in the natural law, showing the importance of both the individual truth and the societal.

Society is a mutual agreement between humans to work together for the benefit of everyone. This idea of mutualistic benefits is what leads to the creation of the common good. The common good is the true intention of societies and the purpose of it. Society pushes for the common good, and knowing this allows for people to make better use of it. Humans have come to realize that the common good is the truth of society and its true purpose. Technology also builds upon this base of society. Society's effectiveness relies heavily on how productive and connected it is. Technology helps fortify these ideas as it allows for these ideas to be followed through on while also making the common good more prevalent. It enables humans to reach a greater common good with increased efficiency. Thus, leading to a better life for everyone involved inside the society.

Technology's first role in the path to a virtuous life is its ability to reveal. The ability to reveal dangers and threats to the existence of the human race is what makes technology so important. This revelation occurs in many different ways. It increases knowledge and uncovers lies. Technology also leads to smarter and better decisions as ignorance is wiped away. This realization of knowledge is found in *A Connecticut Yankee* by Mark Twain. Hank uses technology to transform an inefficient medieval world into a better-functioning paradise for those within. He does this step by step, showing how technology can truly change a world. He starts by identifying the problem of poverty and looking for solutions to combat the current system, which favored the lords and knights over the common peasants.

Hank starts the process of reformation by creating telephones and establishing newspapers. His goal is to connect the different parts of the countryside together to unite them. Here it is evident that society plays an important part when changing the world. Without connecting the people into a unified state, Hank would be unable to teach and improve the lives of the people. Ignorance would continue to run rampant in the world and keep everyone from reaching a virtuous life. The process of improving the individual's life with truth also includes the improvement of the society. This also solves another major issue for him. That issue is the danger of fraud and lies. Before this level of communication, it was simple for people to feed lies. With no way of verifying the truth, the people were stuck with accepting all statements as true, including those of lies. While trust is important to living a virtuous life, being too trusting can be detrimental to the virtuous life. Hank experiences this firsthand when someone pretends to be a magician. This character claims to have the ability to see across the world and be able to tell you what someone was doing at the time. He would then proceed to make up fake actions. This character quickly made a name for himself. Hank realizes that people were gullible and too trusting due to a lack of communication. The people were "ready to take up with an adventurer who could offer no evidence of his powers but his mere unproven word" (Twain, 178). The magician also questions the authenticity of Hank. The people believed the word of this new man over Hank even after Hank had performed many of these so-called miracles of his own. Here is where technology comes into play. Hank uses his new and improved communication system to set a trap for the fraud. He had the fraud predict what King Arthur was doing and then told King Arthur to arrive, thus proving him a liar. Hank's use of technology not only shows technology's ability to reveal but also how technology can be used as a solution.

Technology once again shows its existence as a solution within the medical world. Hank recognizes the state of the people and how they disregard hygiene. He reveals how people put up with a lack of hygiene and accept it because they do not understand the truth behind health and well-being. During his adventure with Sandy, a common peasant, Hank “[pined] for a bath” but observed that Sandy “was fresh as a squirrel; she had slept like the dead; and as for a bath...was not missing it” (84). Here the common person in that day and age was not healthy and well-kept but rather comfortable without a bath after trudging through dirty land for the whole day. In this time period, people did not understand the importance of hygiene and how it leads to shorter life spans. The lack of knowledge is shown to be prevalent as the people are scared of using soap. Hank himself notes that to convert people to believe in soap, he has to clean a hermit to prove the harmlessness of soap. This is a prime example of the dangers of ignorance. Here, soap, something good, is seen as witchcraft and cautioned against. This is why developments within the educational fields are important. It is imperative that humans use technology to combat ignorance and reveal the truth.

However, technology plays a much bigger role than just revealing. It is also a tool that can be used to defend against the dangers to society it reveals. Some of the dangers that have already been identified include ignorance and fraud. Technology offers a simple but effective solution to these problems. This solution takes form in education and schools. Hank creates schools and sends the next generation to become educated. With this newfound knowledge, he shows how irrational the current systems are. An example of this irrationality is when the king goes about assembling his personal army. He plans on choosing men based on their worthiness. Hank and his military students attempt to be chosen as part of this group. Here it is revealed that the king favors the nobility over everything. Hank remarks about this, saying, “That is an

astonishing thing. What good is such a qualification as that?” (188). The people value the wrong qualities, which reduces the overall effectiveness of the cause. The developments of schools and education are necessary to change the misconceptions that people tend to value. The expansion of educational fields would further learning and help improve society while also allowing individuals to learn and pursue different crafts. This will inevitably push humans towards the individual truth as they are given opportunities to discover all kinds of knowledge.

The importance of education can once again be found when Hank visits a group of monks at their monastery. These monks have a holy fountain that has recently stopped working. Due to their superstitious beliefs, they assumed that the blockage was caused by spirits. This led the monks to grow wary of the fountain. The lack of knowledge made them jump to conclusions and irrationally fear something that was not there. However, when Hank looked at the well, he saw that it was “an ordinary well, [and] it had been dug in the ordinary way and stoned up in the ordinary way” (154). Without the truth, the monks hold themselves back from having water. Not only does technology reveal the problem, but it is also the solution. Due to the natural rock blockage covering the water, Hank uses another technological advancement. He uses gunpowder and explosives to destroy the fallen debris to allow the water to flow again. This is how even destructive technology like explosives can be used to enlighten humankind.

While technology can be dangerous, it can also be used to defend against the dangers. Technology is used to protect the ideals and cultures of the human race from extinction. For example, after Hank developed the kingdom into a more modern city, he was confronted by one of the few remaining dangers left. This danger is the Church. Hank acknowledges the importance of religion in a world and how it greatly impacts the culture; however, the current Church was corrupt and power-hungry. It ruled the people from the shadows, and the people were not aware



of this. With the inclusion of education and knowledge, the church was soon revealed as a threat to human prosperity. The Church starts the offensive by issuing an interdict. This resets the old generation Hank tries to improve, and they rally against Hank and anyone left standing with him. By the time Hank is given the news, he is left with himself and a few kids of the new generation. With the odds stacked against him, Hank demonstrates technology's capabilities as a protector. He and the remaining kids set up electric wires and explosives. They were able to hold off the Church and defeat all those that opposed them and their ideals. The power of technology helped preserve the work it has done in the reformation of the society. Without this power, Hank and the kids would be left at the mercy of the Church. These militaristic advancements are imperative to defending and reinforcing new ideals. While this power could be used for good or evil, this ability is priceless to the creation of better societies. The power to defend what is right is what will ultimately help humanity evolve. While it is still true that it could be used for evil, the tradeoff is worth it, as without technology, humanity and society would stay primitive and confused.

Technologies are used to preserve ideals many times. In addition to the large-scale invasion of the Church, it was also used against the smaller threat of the Knights. During the initial reformation process, a lot of the knights were against change because they wanted to stay as knights and keep the human race from progressing into a more sophisticated society. They plotted to kill Hank in the guise of a public event. It starts with a duel that eventually escalates to Hank being stormed by hundreds of knights. While Hank readily accepted the challenge, without technology he would have been defenseless. After Hank notices the unrest within the Knights, he challenges all of them, and if he wins, they disband. During this fight he was pitted against a force 100 times greater. He alone defeated the knights using the technological advancement of

guns. Hank is able to show the terrifying power but also the incredible potential of technology while defending his ideals. The importance of this is that potential oppressors of the virtuous life are no longer a threat. People are able to freely follow Hank into a brighter future and live virtuous lives. Without the influence of the knights, the people can rebuild the society to be greater using the new technologies being developed. During this process, they are able to explore their passions and better themselves by working towards that moral code. Thus both conditions of the virtuous life can be reached.

The societal part of the virtuous life is also necessary. Technology plays an important role in society as well. As mentioned before, there is a danger that threatens the existence of humanity. Technology is both the cause and the solution to this danger. This is due to the misuse of technology by humans. As mentioned before, Hank uses technology to connect and maximize the efficiency of the society. This is where the danger occurs. Heidegger is worried that humanity will become over-reliant on the use of technology and end up losing its purpose as a people. While maximizing efficiency is important and can free humans to pursue virtuous life, it has to be done slowly. The danger becomes apparent when too many jobs are taken over by technology, and people end up supervising the technology. Not only are crafts being replaced with technology, but the humans are also not fully free to pursue their passions. However, at the same time, Heidegger also acknowledges the fact that technology is also humanity's saving grace. The reason to use technology despite its dangers lies in both its benefits and its potential. It allows for the societal side of a virtuous life to be achieved. This is because it can connect the society and increase efficiency, thus freeing people to work on themselves and the individual side of the virtuous life. Technology also boosts production capabilities, enabling the transportation of

resources to everyone inside the society. So while technology has its risks, when used correctly, it can not only stop the danger but also improve society more than ever imagined.

Now let's consider the alternative: what life would be like without the implementation of technology. Before Hank arrived in Old England, there was a clear divide between the nobles and the peasants. The nobles could do whatever they pleased, and the peasants were forced to obey the nobles. While hierarchies are unavoidable, this clear divide meant there was a lack of human unity and progression as a race. This divide also means that the common people have no opportunities to better themselves. Without the introduction of technology, the lives of these people were mundane and fruitless. Their mindlessness and lack of individuality are apparent in the fact that they were controlled by the church without realizing it. However, there is still an argument to be made that technology is not a necessity for a better life. This argument takes form in that of *Utopia* by Thomas Moore. In *Utopia* the “perfect society” is a society without much technology, with everyone being supposedly virtuous and living a good life. So how does technology play into this? Technology is a means to better oneself. The lives that the utopians live are very similar to that of the peasants from King Arthur’s court. They have a strict schedule and are only focused on serving the common good. While a fully flushed-out schedule appears to be perfect as the common good is tied to the truth of a society and leads to the virtuous life, it skips a step of the individual leading a virtuous life. What you end up with is a society that is efficient but consists of passionless people. As mentioned earlier, both the individual and societal truths must be reached, and the societal one alone is not enough. Without individualism, the people are not truly living. They resemble automatons and may be virtuous but ultimately are all identical. Part of human truth is to discover values that are intrinsic to the individual. One of the main reasons why this issue is relevant lies in the fact that the Utopians are forced to follow a

strict schedule. With the introduction of technology, they are granted a path towards discovering truth. The time they currently waste on jobs can be reduced and replaced with learning, self-betterment, and individuality. With the current system of Utopia dependent on the fact that every single individual is hardworking, the society would progress the individuals towards a more virtuous life. The usual drawbacks of lazy people taking advantage of others are also avoided.

Within the society of Utopia, there exists a lack of freedom. Every citizen is expected to act in a specific manner that has the sole goal of the common good. While the common good is important, the state of a society is dependent upon the individuals inside it. Both societal and individual truths are necessary to reach the level of existence where all of humanity is virtuous. Without the applications of technology, the citizens are forced to incorporate a large part of their time into actions that take away from them discovering their identity. This is a problem because the people act like machines and robots and lose their personal identity and truth. An example of this would be if a person is forced to do repetitive, boring manual labor like construction because the city lacks construction members while they yearn to be a craftsman and make pots. Even though Utopia tries to account for each individual's passion, the people are stuck filling in jobs and not having time to experience and discover their true passion and joy. While a person's truth and identity do rely on their job and abilities, the lack of technology would eventually force people into a situation where they cannot discover individual passions. While societal truth is important, individuality is equally important to reach a virtuous life. Within Utopia, the Utopians are told how to act and what to pursue. Without technology and its improvements, it becomes increasingly difficult to gain knowledge and find out what their intrinsic values truly are. This lack of individuality is revealed through the children as the "majority of children are brought up

in the occupation of their father, for almost all of them are drawn to it by nature” (Moore 64).

While Utopia allows those who are drawn to other crafts to learn those other crafts, they must in turn give up their family. It is clear that the children are drawn to their father's craft through nature due to familiarity. However, this also means that they are not given any chances to truly explore the different kinds of crafts. The lack of individuality and experience during childhood is what prevents the Utopians from reaching a true virtuous life. Here is where technology comes into play. Technology can solve this issue of lack of opportunities. Technology can support the Utopians whenever they have a shortage of people in a certain career, thus letting the future generation be allowed more time to discover all types of careers. Not only does technology free up more time; its influence exists within schools as well. It allows kids to gain hands-on experience and discover different types of careers.

The danger Heidegger worries about is now a lot more visible. Heidegger explains technology as a form of revealing that shows the truth. Heidegger acknowledges the fact that technology is extremely effective at what it does, which is revealing the truth to humans and making life more efficient. However, he worries that this extreme type of revealing will lead to the downfall of humanity. The danger is that this type of revealing pushes everything it reveals to the limit. And if the limit is crossed, the original purpose of the object is lost. He shows the dangers of technology with his example of the Rhine River. The original purpose of the river is to supply water to the life forms along its route. However, once humans use technology to transform the Rhine into a power plant, the original purpose is weakened. While Heidegger is right to be cautious, the use of technology can be used in tandem with nature. As long as the limit is not crossed, technology can lead to a world of balance where nature and technology can work together. This coexistent world is the mean of the extremes, meaning that it is the best of

both worlds and allows for maximum efficiency without taking away from the original purpose. Humans need to learn to embrace technology but also maintain their connection with the intrinsic value of humans. With the inclusion of technology in society, efficiency and time can be maximized, thus allowing for the most potential to grow. So while Heidegger is right to worry, it does not mean that humans should shy away from technology; rather, they need to understand it and use it in moderation.

Some people would argue that technology leads to a loss of truth. They would say, like Heidegger, that when we let machines and technology control us, it leads to humans losing their purpose. While this is true, the importance is to not let technology control us. Technology is and will always be a tool for humanity. When we take technology away from the purpose of a tool, that is where we run into the dangers previously mentioned. But this does not take away from the fact that technology is used to reveal the truth and help humanity progress. Like all things, when something is taken away completely from its true purpose, it will cease to help like it was truly meant to. It is true that technology can be dangerous; however, it is also a gift. Its ability to evolve and push the human race to be better is invaluable, and its potential is limitless. Technology can be referred to as a double-edged sword for this reason; however, it is a sword that is worth wielding.

Another common solution that people offer in search of truth is that of poetry and the arts. These also reveal the truth but in a much more peaceful way. They emphasize expressing emotion and learning about yourself through words. Specifically, the arts focus on bringing out hidden emotions and feelings through the use of words. While these things can help show the truth towards a virtuous life, without the influence of technology, a person cannot reach a virtuous life with the arts alone. A major issue would be that society would struggle to sustain

itself if everyone were to turn to the arts. Without the use of machinery to help till crops, connect people together, transport goods, and much more, society would cease to exist. Not only is the societal part of virtue broken, but the individual part will struggle as well. This is because technology shows things as they are; for example, a person's greed could be revealed by technology, while the arts will always be in blissful ignorance in this regard. Without the revealing of technology, both society and the individual will fail to reach a virtuous life. While poetry and the arts have their own role within society, they cannot measure up to the level of revealing that technology brings about. This is why the arts are seen as a peaceful alternative to technology in self-revelation. However, it cannot negate the necessity of using technology. Technologies abilities are why Heidegger says, "The danger is the saving power, inasmuch as it brings the saving power out of its—the danger's—concealed essence" (Heidegger 42). Here Heidegger reveals the biggest difference between the arts and technology. Technology reveals the truth in a way that shows the whole truth, even though it brings about danger. The arts are incapable of this level of revealing. Within this danger lies humanity's saving grace. This is that perfect balance between nature and technology. Without assuming the risk of danger, humanity will never be able to reach its full potential. So while the arts are still important, technology plays a role that cannot be replaced by any other way of revealing.

In conclusion, learning the truth is the most important step to reach a virtuous life. To achieve a virtuous life, both parts are necessary, namely the societal part and the individual part. Without each of these pieces, the virtuous life cannot be reached. The societal part deals with the common good, and it impacts how humans coexist together to benefit everyone. The individual part deals with both what it means to be a human and the uniqueness of each individual. The best way of obtaining these truths is through the use of technology. Many people would suggest using

poetry and the arts instead due to their lack of risk; however, without risk, the reward is greatly diminished. While they can reveal part of the truth, they are unable to reveal the full, raw truth. This leaves humanity with the sole option of using technology. While technology does have its drawbacks, its potential far outweighs the dangers. This potential shines through technology's ability to reveal the world in its purest form. When using technology, there is no attempt to present the world as something other than what it truly is. After technology reveals the problems and dangers, it will then offer itself as the solution or part of the solution. After the danger is prevented, technology's final use comes into play, which is also arguably the most important of the three abilities. The last use of technology is its ability to defend and secure new ideals. This ability is what is most commonly feared, as this form of technology is the most dangerous. And while this is an understandable fear, the reward of a virtuous life for all of humanity far outweighs the risk of destruction. The true purpose of humanity is to evolve as a race and improve the lives of everyone through the creation of societies. Technology has the greatest potential to help us with this goal. The gift of technology should be used sparingly, but if used correctly, it is humanity's greatest asset. Technology demonstrates the fact that it is humanity's greatest asset when Utopia is taken into consideration. Utopia, a seemingly perfect society untouched by technology, shows why technology's influence is so important. The few downsides to Utopia all point to the necessity of technology. Technology solves the primary issue of a lack of individuality as it allows for the Utopians to diversify and discover the endless possibilities within the world. Technology's impact is why it is the key to unlocking the virtuous lifestyle. With that being said, it should become clear why understanding the influence of technology is important. Not only does it already play a large role in modern day, but it is also the solution to saving the world from ruin and leading it to a brighter future. While its dangers are apparent, the



reward it proposes far outweighs the dangers. Risk is always a necessity when trying to make change, and the importance is to fully understand the situation. Due to the transparency of the dangers technology brings with it, if caution is used, the dangers can be mitigated. Whether humanity wants it or not, technology is here, and the future awaits.

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